

DUCKS, GEESE, AND SWANS

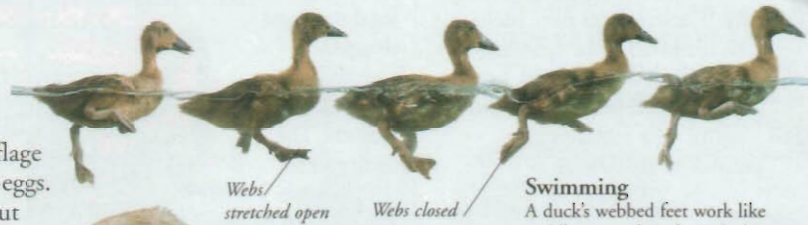
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MOST DUCKS, GEESE, AND SWANS spend their life on or near water. They belong to a family of birds called waterfowl and are closely related to each other. They have broad beaks and short legs with webbed feet. They are good swimmers and have waterproof plumage, which keeps them dry and also helps them to float. There are about 160 species of waterfowl in the wild. Some species of duck and goose have been domesticated and are often raised on farms.

Ducks

Ducks are the smallest and most varied waterfowl. Males are often brightly coloured and females are usually drab, which helps to camouflage them when they are sitting on their eggs. Some ducks live in coastal waters, but most live on rivers, lakes, and ponds.



Khaki Campbell – a domestic duck

Webs stretched open

Webs closed

Swimming

A duck's webbed feet work like paddles to push it through the water. When it pushes its feet backward, it spreads its toes to stretch out the webs between them. When it pulls its feet forward, it closes its toes to shut the webs, which then offer less water resistance.

Plumage

Ducks produce a waterproof oil from a gland near the base of their tail. When they preen their feathers, they spread the oil over them. This oil is so effective that a duck stays dry even when it dives beneath the surface.

Swans

The largest waterfowl are swans, with a wingspan of up to 2.3 m (7.5 ft). Most of the eight species are white, but the Australian black swan has a black body and white flight feathers. A swan spends a lot of its time on water. It uses its long neck to reach plants below the surface.



Mute swan has a black knob at the base of its beak.

Mute swan egg is an oval shape.



Swan egg

Young swans

Young swans, or cygnets, stay with their parents for a whole year, which is a long time for a bird. When they develop their adult plumage, their parents drive them away.

Nesting swans

Swans nest on the ground close to the water's edge. The female incubates the eggs for up to 38 days, and she hisses loudly at anything that comes too close. If her warnings are ignored, she attacks. Her powerful beak and wings make formidable weapons.



Geese

Unlike most waterfowl, geese usually feed on land. They eat grass, gripping it in their beaks and pulling it up with a tug. Many geese breed in the tundra of the far north. These white-fronted geese, seen here in western Scotland, fly north to Greenland after the winter.



Swan takeoff

Swans can weigh up to 13 kg (28.5 lb), which makes them among the world's heaviest flying birds. Swans cannot take off from a standing start. Instead, they have to run across the water to gain enough speed for takeoff.



With its wings held wide, the duckling jumps.

Big feet and stubby wings work like parachutes to slow the duckling's fall.

A Mandarin duckling leaves the nest in response to its mother's call.

A tree duckling must jump before it is a day old to find food.

Tree-nesting ducks

Most ducks nest on the ground but a few lay their eggs in holes in trees. Soon after the young have hatched, their mother leaves the nest and calls to them to follow her. The ducklings are too young to fly, and instead they jump to the ground.

MUTE SWAN

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Cygnus olor*

ORDER Anseriformes

FAMILY Anatidae

DISTRIBUTION Western Europe, parts of central Asia; also introduced into other parts of the world, including North America, Australia, and New Zealand

HABITAT Lakes and rivers

DIET Water plants

SIZE Length: 152 cm (60 in)

LIFESPAN About 20 years

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